THE ROMANTASY WORLDBUILDING WORKBOOK

Build worlds worth falling in love in.

What This Is

This is a worldbuilding workbook designed specifically for romantasy — fantasy romance where the world isn't just backdrop, but an active force shaping and pressuring the love story.

In romantasy, worldbuilding isn't separate from romance. The political marriage that forces enemies together, the magical bond that connects two people against their will, the ancient feud that makes love forbidden, the class divide that seems impossible to cross — these aren't setting details. They're the engine of your story.

This workbook helps you build worlds that create romantic tension by design.

Who This Is For

This workbook is for writers who want to:

- Build fantasy worlds that feel real and internally consistent
- Create external obstacles that pressure and test relationships
- Understand how geography, politics, magic, culture, and history can generate romantic conflict
- Move beyond generic fantasy settings to worlds that could only produce *your* story
- Develop worldbuilding that readers will want to live in

Whether you're writing your first romantasy or your tenth, whether you're a plotter who needs everything mapped before drafting or a pantser who discovers your world as you go — this workbook meets you where you are.

How This Workbook Is Structured

Each section follows a two-part structure:

Part One: The Foundation

This is the worldbuilding itself — how your geography, magic, government, religion, economy, culture, or history actually works. These elements exist in your world regardless of your characters' romantic situation.

Strong foundations make your world feel real. Readers can tell when a world has depth versus when it's cardboard scenery hastily assembled behind the love story.

Part Two: [Topic] & Romance

This is where worldbuilding becomes romantic tension. Each section shows you how to mine its topic for obstacles, intimacy, stakes, and conflict specific to love stories.

A magic system isn't just about what spells exist — it's about what happens when one character is vastly more powerful than the other, or when a magical bond forces intimacy neither chose, or when using power for someone you love costs something real.

REMEMBER

You need both parts. A romance between a servant and a prince needs a believable class system (foundation) that actually creates stakes and obstacles for their relationship (romance application). Skip the foundation and your world feels thin. Skip the romance application and you're not using your world to its full potential.

How to Use This Workbook

You Don't Have to Do Everything

This workbook is comprehensive — intentionally so. Not every section will apply to your story. Not every question will be relevant.

Skip freely. If your story doesn't involve inter-species romance, skip that section. If religion isn't a factor, move past it. If your characters aren't part of an institution, those questions aren't for you.

The goal isn't to fill every blank. The goal is to build what your specific story needs.

You Don't Have to Go in Order

The sections are numbered for reference, not because you must complete them sequentially.

Some writers start with magic because that's the heart of their world. Others start with the political situation that creates their central conflict. Some build geography first because place shapes everything else.

Start wherever you have the most energy or the clearest vision. Let that section inform the others.

Focus on What Creates Stakes

As you work through each section, keep asking: **How does this create obstacles for my characters?**

Not every piece of worldbuilding needs to directly pressure the romance — some details just make the world feel real. But if you find yourself developing elaborate systems that never touch your love story, you might be worldbuilding for worldbuilding's sake rather than story's sake.

The best romantasy worldbuilding does double duty: it makes the world feel real *and* it makes the romance feel impossible (until it isn't).

Use the Integration Checks

At the end of each section, you'll find Integration Checks — questions that connect that section's topic to others. These are important.

Worlds feel real when their systems interact. A magic system affects government (who has power). Religion shapes culture (what's taboo). History explains current politics (why the feud exists). Geography determines economy (who controls resources).

If each section exists in isolation, your world will feel like a collection of unrelated details. Integration Checks help you weave everything together.

Examples Are Guides, Not Rules

Throughout this workbook, you'll find examples drawn from popular romantasy novels — ACOTAR, Fourth Wing, From Blood and Ash, Serpent & Dove, and others. These show what good answers look like and what level of specificity is useful.

But these examples aren't templates to copy. Your world should be *yours*. Use the examples to understand the kind of thinking these questions invite, then develop answers that serve your unique story.

A Note on Tropes

Romantasy is a trope-heavy genre, and that's not a weakness — it's a feature. Readers come to romantasy *wanting* enemies-to-lovers, forced proximity, forbidden love, fated mates, morally grey love interests, and "there's only one bed."

This workbook doesn't shy away from tropes. Instead, it helps you execute them well.

The difference between a tired trope and a beloved one isn't the trope itself — it's the execution. An enemies-to-lovers romance where the enmity is shallow and easily overcome is boring. An enemies-to-lovers romance where both characters have genuine, legitimate reasons to hate each other — where choosing love means betraying everything they believed — that's compelling.

CORE PRINCIPLE

Worldbuilding is how you make tropes feel earned.

The forced proximity isn't just "they're stuck together" — it's the specific institution, geography, political situation, or magical bond that makes escape impossible.

The forbidden love isn't just "they're not supposed to be together" — it's the specific laws, cultural taboos, religious strictures, or historical enmity that makes their love dangerous.

Build your world to support your tropes, and your tropes will sing.

Before You Begin

You don't need to know your whole story before starting. Many writers discover their plots through worldbuilding — realizing that the magic system they developed creates a perfect obstacle, or that the political situation they built suggests an ending they hadn't considered.

Let the worldbuilding work *with* your story, not as a separate task you complete before writing.

And remember: worldbuilding exists to serve the story. A beautifully detailed world that doesn't create stakes for your characters is just a setting guide. A sparse world that perfectly pressures your romance is doing its job.

Build what you need. Skip what you don't. Make a world worth falling in love in.

The Sections

SECTION	TOPIC	WHAT IT COVERS
1	Geography & Environment	Physical world, climate, travel, how place creates obstacles
2	Flora, Fauna & Ecosystems	Plants, animals, bonded creatures, inter-species romance
3	Culture, Customs & Daily Life	Social norms, taboos, courtship, what's forbidden
4	Economy, Labor & Resources	Wealth, class, debt, what money means for love
5	Government, Power & Law	Politics, law, forbidden relationships, enemies-to-lovers
6	Religion, Myth & Prophecy	Faith, vows, divine purpose, what the gods demand
7	History & Lore	The past that haunts the present, inherited conflict
8	Magic System	How magic works, magical bonds, power dynamics

Additional Sections (9–21) cover specialized topics: technology, time & calendar, language, magic conflicts, pressure cooker settings, institutions, and more.

Appendix A: Revealing Worldbuilding in Prose — A practical guide to deploying your worldbuilding in scenes without info-dumps.

Let's Begin

Turn to whichever section calls to you first. There's no wrong starting point.

Your world is waiting to be built.

SECTION ONE

GEOGRAPHY & ENVIRONMENT

Geography isn't just a map — it's the landscape that shapes everything else. Mountains create borders that become political divisions. Deserts isolate cultures. Rivers determine where cities grow. Control of fertile valleys determines who holds power.

In This Section

Concepts & Frameworks

- How to Think About Geography
- Common Geographic Patterns
- Common Mistakes
- Reference: Travel Times

Part One: The Foundation

- The Big Picture: World's Scale
- Terrain Types
- Resources & Territorial Control
- The Sensory World
- Climate, Weather & Seasons
- Dangerous Regions
- Borders & Boundaries

Part Two: Geography & Romance

- Home & Belonging
- Entering Each Other's Worlds
- Travel & Distance
- Isolated Locations
- Geography as Emotional Landscape
- Integration Check
- Quick Reference

This section is divided into two parts:

Part One: The Foundation — The physical reality of your world. Terrain, climate, resources, dangers, and how geography shapes where and how people live. This is the geographic baseline that exists regardless of your characters' romantic situation.

Part Two: Geography & Romance — How physical geography creates romantic tension. Separation and proximity, dangerous journeys together, entering each other's worlds, places that hold emotional meaning.

You need both.

A Note Before You Begin

Not every question will apply to your story. **Skip what doesn't fit.**

Worldbuild for its own sake if you want. A richly developed world has value beyond what appears on the page. Use the "romance connection" prompts for brainstorming if they're helpful, or leave them blank if that element is just background texture.

Come back later. If you're not sure whether something matters yet, skip it and return once your story has taken more shape.

This workbook is a tool, not a test.

How to Think About Geography in Romantasy

Geography in romantasy functions as a **pressure system** — the physical world can compress your characters together, force them apart, or create conditions where they must rely on each other. Before you draw a map, ask yourself: *What geographic situation does my romance need?*

Not every hill and river needs to serve the plot. But the geography you emphasize — the locations where scenes happen, the terrain your characters traverse, the distances between them — should be doing something. Background geography creates atmosphere and believability. Foreground geography creates story.

THE GEOGRAPHY-AS-FRICTION FRAMEWORK

Develop geography that creates friction — between your characters, or between what they want and what they can have.

Separation Friction What physical obstacles keep them apart?

- Different kingdoms separated by mountains
- An ocean that takes months to cross
- A magical barrier that can only be crossed under certain conditions
- War zones that make travel deadly

Proximity Friction What forces them together despite themselves?

- A snowed-in mountain pass
- A ship voyage with no escape
- An isolated estate or academy
- A dangerous journey requiring partnership

Resource Friction What geographic scarcity creates conflict?

- Water rights in a desert region
- The only pass through the mountains
- A rare magical resource found in contested territory
- Trade routes that require cooperation between enemies

Geography that doesn't create friction isn't wasted — it's just setting.

THE "PRESSURE COOKER" PRINCIPLE

> *The most effective romantasy settings function as pressure cookers — environments that trap characters together and force interaction. When characters can't escape each other, they're forced to confront conflict instead of avoiding it, rely on each other despite distrust, and share space long enough for attraction to build beneath their defenses.*

Reference: Place Name Patterns

Common English Place Name Patterns

Mix prefixes and suffixes to generate names. "Ash" + "ford" = Ashford. "Black" + "moor" = Blackmoor.

PREFIX	MEANING	EXAMPLE
Ash-	ash tree	Ashford, Ashby
Black-	dark, black	Blackmoor, Blackpool
Brad- / Broad-	broad, wide	Bradford, Broadstairs
East- / West- / North- / South-	direction	Eastbourne, Westbury
Glen- / Green-	valley / green	Glendale, Greenfield
Hol- / Hollow-	hollow, low-lying	Holmfirth, Holbrook
King- / Bishop-	royal / church estate	Kingston, Bishopstoke
Long-	long, extended	Longford, Longdale
New- / Old-	new / old	Newcastle, Oldham
Stone- / Stan-	stone, rocky	Stoneham, Stamford
Whit- / White-	white	Whitby, Whitfield

SUFFIX	MEANING	EXAMPLE
-ham	homestead, village	Nottingham
-ton / -town	fenced settlement	Brighton
-ford	river crossing	Oxford
-ley / -leigh	clearing, meadow	Barnsley
-dale / -vale	valley	Airedale
-burgh / -bury	fortified place	Edinburgh
-port	harbor, market town	Southport
-moor / -mere	marshland, lake	Windermere
-fell / -mount	hill, mountain	Scafell
-holme / -holm	island, water meadow	Stockholm

Nordic/Scandinavian Place Name Patterns

Good for cold, northern, Viking-inspired settings. Old Norse roots appear in many English place names too.

PREFIX	MEANING	EXAMPLE
Stor- / Stór-	great, large	Storfjord, Stóravatn
Ny- / Nýr-	new	Nykøbing, Nýdalur
Holm-	small island	Holmsland, Stockholm
Nor- / Norð-	north	Norðfjörður, Norway
Suð- / Sör-	south	Suðureyri, Sörmland
Stein-	stone, rock	Steinkjer, Steinberg
Kvit- / Hvít-	white	Kvitfjell, Hvítá
Svar- / Svart-	black, dark	Svartskog, Svartengren
Eld-	fire	Eldfjall, Eldhús
Is- / Ís-	ice	Island (Iceland), Ísafjörður

SUFFIX	MEANING	EXAMPLE
-by	farm, settlement	Whitby, Grimsby
-vik / -wick	bay, inlet	Reykjavik, Lerwick
-fjord / -firth	long narrow inlet	Sognefjord
-heim / -hem	home, world	Trondheim
-berg / -borg	mountain / fortress	Gothenburg
-dal / -dalen	valley	Gudvangen
-ness / -nes	headland, promontory	Skagen
-stad / -sted	place, site	Halstead
-land	land, territory	Iceland, Gotland
-thwaite	clearing, meadow	Braithwaite

Celtic/Welsh Place Name Patterns

Good for mystical, ancient, fae-adjacent settings. Celtic names often describe landscape features poetically.

ELEMENT	MEANING	EXAMPLE
Aber-	river mouth	Aberdeen, Aberystwyth
Caer- / Car-	fort, stronghold	Caernarfon, Cardiff
Llan-	church, sacred enclosure	Llandudno
Pen-	head, top, end	Penrith, Penzance
Tre- / Tref-	homestead, town	Tremaine
Dun- / Din-	hill fort	Edinburgh (Dun Edin)
-combe / -cwm	valley	Ilfracombe
Glyn- / Glen-	valley	Glencoe
Loch- / Lough-	lake	Lochaber
Inver- / Innis-	river mouth / island	Inverness

Slavic Place Name Patterns

Good for Eastern European-inspired settings. Slavic names often use descriptive compounds.

ELEMENT	MEANING	EXAMPLE
-grad / -gorod	city, fortified place	Belgrade, Novgorod
-ov / -ova / -ovo	belonging to (possessive)	Sarajevo, Krakow
Novo- / Novy-	new	Novosibirsk
Staro- / Stary-	old	Starograd
-pol / -pole	field	Sevastopol
Belo- / Byelo-	white	Belgrade (Beograd)
Cerno- / Cherno-	black	Chernobyl
-ice / -itz	place suffix	Katowice
-sk / -sko	place/region suffix	Gdansk, Minsk
Veliko- / Veliky-	great, large	Veliky Novgorod

Your World's Place Name Patterns

Create prefixes and suffixes that fit your world's languages. What sounds right for this culture?

PREFIX/SUFFIX	MEANING	EXAMPLE IN YOUR WORLD
Kel- / -kel	*silver, moonlight*	*Kelvareth (Silver City)*

The Big Picture: Your World's Scale

What's the geographic scope of your story?
Check the scope that best fits your story, then note the primary locations where your romance actually takes place.

SCOPE	✓	PRIMARY LOCATION(S)
Single city/location (isolated island, palace, academy)	✓	*Thornwick Academy — a remote magical school on sea cliffs where students are trapped together for the term*
Single city/location		
Single region (kingdom, province, territory)		
Multiple regions (nations, continents)		
Entire world (epic scope)		
Multiple worlds/realms (parallel dimensions, portals)		

Other: Describe		

If your world is large, where specifically does your romance happen?
You don't need to detail everything — just locations that matter.

LOCATION TYPE	NAME/DESCRIPTION
Primary location	*The Winter Court — an ice palace where protagonist is held hostage, forced into proximity with the prince*
Primary location	
Secondary location	
Secondary location	

Kingdoms & Nations Overview

This is reference material. Fill in what you know now; come back as your world develops.

ASPECT	KINGDOM/NATION 1	KINGDOM/NATION 2
Name		
Capital		
Neighbouring lands		
Known for		
Main industry/resource		

Climate		
Primary species		
Religion		
Government type		
Allies		
Enemies/rivals		
Notable landmark		

Role in your story		

Terrain Types

Only fill in terrains that matter. If your characters never see a desert, skip it.

What terrains shape your story?

TERRAIN	WHERE?	WHAT IT PROVIDES	WHAT CHALLENGES IT CREATES
Mountains	*Northern border between kingdoms*	*Natural defense, mineral deposits, isolation for monasteries*	*Impassable in winter, separates lovers from different kingdoms, treacherous passes*

Resources & Territorial Control

Reference: Natural Resource Ideas

Use this list for inspiration when filling out the table below.

CATEGORY	EXAMPLES
Precious Metals	Gold, silver, copper, iron ore, bronze, platinum, mithril
Gems & Stones	Diamonds, rubies, sapphires, emeralds, pearls, amber, jade, obsidian, marble
Textiles	Silk, wool, linen, cotton, rare furs, leather, spider-silk, feathers
Food & Agriculture	Grain, rice, olives, wine/grapes, sugar, honey, salt, spices, rare fruits
Animal Products	Ivory, bone, whale oil, animal fat, beeswax, dyes from shells, ambergris
Plant Products	Timber, herbs, medicinal plants, rare flowers, resins, incense, tea, coffee
Fuel & Energy	Coal, oil, charcoal, peat, magical crystals, dragon-fire, captured lightning
Magical Resources	Ley line access, enchanted springs, magical creatures, spell components
Curiosities	Fossils, adder stones, meteoric iron, ancient artifacts, bottled starlight

What natural resources are geographically concentrated?
Think beyond the obvious. What does this world have that ours doesn't? What scarcity shapes daily life?

RESOURCE	WHERE IT'S FOUND	WHO CONTROLS IT

Fertile farmland	*River valley between the two kingdoms*	*Contested — marriage alliance proposed to end the conflict*
Fertile farmland		
Fresh water		
Timber/forests		
Mineral deposits		
Coastal access/ports		
Mountain passes		
Magical resources		

What geographic resource creates tension or conflict in your world?

Water rights? Arable land? Trade routes? Does the conflict show up as war, political marriage, trade embargo, or something subtler?

YOUR ANSWER

How does geographic resource control affect your characters?

Does one character's family/nation control something the other's needs? Is there territorial dispute between their peoples?

YOUR ANSWER

Continue in Section 4

You've mapped where resources are found and who controls them. In Section 4: Resources & Scarcity, you'll explore how resource control creates economic stakes, cultural traditions, and romantic tension.

The Sensory World

What does your primary setting look, sound, smell, and feel like?
Close your eyes and walk through this place. What hits your senses first? What would your protagonist notice?

SENSE	DESCRIPTION
What you see	
What you hear	
What you smell	
What the air feels like (temperature, humidity, wind)	

How does the environment change at different times of day?

Dawn meetings feel different than midnight ones. What time of day would be most romantic here? Most dangerous?

TIME	DESCRIPTION
Morning	
Midday	
Evening	
Night	

What's beautiful about this place?

The details a character falling in love would notice. What would make someone homesick for this place?

YOUR ANSWER

What's harsh or uncomfortable about this place?

What do people endure or complain about? What takes getting used to?

YOUR ANSWER

Climate, Weather & Seasons

What's the overall climate?
Tropical, temperate, arid, polar? How does it shape what people wear, build, and grow?

YOUR ANSWER

What seasons exist and how distinct are they?
Traditional four seasons? A long winter and brief summer? Magical seasons tied to something other than the sun?

YOUR ANSWER

What season is your story set in?

Seasons create mood and constraint. What does this season make possible for your romance? What does it prevent?

ASPECT	DETAILS
Season	
What this season makes possible	
What this season makes impossible	

How do seasons affect life in your world?

When can armies march? When do ships sail? When are weddings held? When must everyone stay indoors?

SEASON	WHAT'S POSSIBLE	WHAT'S IMPOSSIBLE
Summer/warm season		

Winter/cold season		
Transitional seasons		

Does the season create pressure or opportunity in your story?
Racing against winter? Waiting for spring thaw? Only able to travel in summer?

YOUR ANSWER

Dangerous Regions

What regions are dangerous or forbidden?
Every world has places people warn you not to go. What makes them deadly? What would force your characters there anyway?

REGION	WHAT MAKES IT DANGEROUS	WHO GOES THERE ANYWAY (AND WHY)

The Blighted Wastes	*Corrupted magic, monsters, no water for miles, disorienting mists*	*Exiles, desperate smugglers, and our protagonists who must cross it to reach sanctuary*

Do your characters travel through dangerous territory?
Shared danger bonds people fast. What threats would force them to rely on each other?

ASPECT	DETAILS
Where and why	

What dangers they face	

Borders & Boundaries

What geographic features create borders?
Mountain ranges? Rivers? Oceans? Magical barriers? Deserts?

YOUR ANSWER

How permeable are these borders?
Easy to cross? Heavily guarded? Physically impassable? Seasonally accessible?

YOUR ANSWER

Do your characters come from opposite sides of a significant border?
Borders create "us" and "them." What assumptions would each character have about someone from the other side?

ASPECT	DETAILS
What separates them	
What crossing means (legally, socially, personally)	

Home & Belonging

Where does your protagonist feel at home?
The place that shaped them, where they feel most themselves:

YOUR ANSWER

What does home look, smell, sound like to them?

The sensory details that mean "home":

YOUR ANSWER

Where does your love interest feel at home?

The place that shaped them, where they're most themselves. How different is it from your protagonist's home?

YOUR ANSWER

Where does each character feel like an outsider?

Fish-out-of-water moments reveal character. Where would each feel uncertain, uncomfortable, or judged?

CHARACTER	WHERE THEY FEEL ALIEN

Protagonist	
Love interest	

Entering Each Other's Worlds

Does one character visit the other's home territory?
Bringing someone home is an act of vulnerability. What would they be proud to show? What would they rather hide?

ASPECT	DETAILS
Who visits whose world	

What's the sensory experience of entering unfamiliar territory?
What do they notice first? What's strange? What's beautiful? What's uncomfortable?

YOUR ANSWER

How does the "native" character see their home differently through the visitor's eyes?
Pride? Shame? New appreciation? Defensiveness?

YOUR ANSWER

What does the visitor understand about their partner after seeing where they come from?
Place explains people. What becomes clear about your love interest once you see where they grew up?

YOUR ANSWER

Travel & Distance

How do people typically travel?
On foot? Horseback? Ships? Flying creatures? Magical transportation?

YOUR ANSWER

Travel Time Reference

These are real-world estimates. Feel free to adjust for your world.

MODE OF TRAVEL	DISTANCE PER DAY	NOTES
Walking (comfortable pace)	15–20 miles / 25–32 km	Healthy adult with breaks
Forced march	25–30 miles / 40–50 km	Exhausting, not sustainable
Riding (sustainable)	25–35 miles / 40–55 km	One horse, regular rest
Hard ride	40–50 miles / 65–80 km	Tiring the horse
Changing horses (relay)	80–100 miles / 130–160 km	Fresh mounts at stations
Sailing ship (favorable wind)	100–150 miles / 160–240 km	Highly variable
Carriage/wagon	20–30 miles / 32–50 km	Roads required

How long does travel take between key locations?
Distance creates stakes. A week apart feels different than a year. How painful is separation in your world?

ROUTE	TRAVEL TIME
From capital to border	
From one character's home to the other's	
Across the dangerous region	

Do your characters undertake a significant journey?
The road is where walls come down. What would a long journey together reveal about each of them?

ASPECT	DETAILS
From where to where	
How long	
What happens during the journey	

Isolated Locations

What isolated locations exist?
Islands, remote estates, mountain fortresses, ships at sea, academies, pocket dimensions:

LOCATION	TYPE	WHY PEOPLE GO	WHY LEAVING IS DIFFICULT
Stormhold Keep	*Remote mountain fortress*	*Political prisoners sent there; protagonist exiled after scandal*	*Mountain passes are snowed in 8 months/year; magic wards prevent unauthorized departure*

Geography as Emotional Landscape

What's the emotional quality of your primary setting?
Does it feel oppressive, expansive, peaceful, threatening, beautiful, decaying?

YOUR ANSWER

Is there a location that becomes meaningful to your characters specifically?
A place they return to, a place where something changed, a place that's "theirs":

YOUR ANSWER

Integration Check

QUESTION	YOUR ANSWER
How does geography explain cultural differences? (Reference: Section 3)	
How does geography create or reinforce power structures? (Reference: Section 5)	
How does geography interact with magic? (Reference: Section 8)	
What geographic resource or territory is contested in your world?	

Quick Reference: Geographic Stakes

ELEMENT	YOUR WORLD
Key location 1	*The Winter Court — where protagonist is hostage and love interest is prince*
Key location 1	
Key location 2	
Key location 3	
The contested resource or territory	
The barrier separating peoples or characters	
The dangerous region	

The isolated location	
The significant journey (from → to)	
The place that matters emotionally	

Map Making: What to Include on Your Map

Consider which of these appear in your world. You don't need all of them.

CATEGORY	POSSIBLE LOCATIONS
Geographic features	Mountains, rivers, forests, lakes, coastlines, islands, deserts, swamps, valleys
Political boundaries	Kingdom borders, disputed territories, neutral zones, conquered lands
Cities & settlements	Capitals, port cities, border towns, villages, abandoned settlements
Trade & travel	Major roads, trade routes, mountain passes, river crossings, ports
Fortifications	Castles, walls, watchtowers, military camps, fortresses
Religious sites	Temples, shrines, pilgrimage routes, sacred groves, forbidden places
Magical locations	Ley lines, magical academies, cursed regions, power sources
Story-specific	Where characters meet, where they're forbidden to go, where they flee to